before long was marching on towards Jalalabad, from which the prostrate Akbar Khan had to be hurriedly removed on a litter.

The capture of Ali Masjid and Ghazni within forty-eight hours of each other encouraged other disaffected tribesmen. In Istalif, thirty-five miles beyond Kabul, the Tajik Kohistanis rose up against the Barakzais under their religious leader, the Naqsbandi Pir and hereditary Imam of the Pul-i-Khishti mosque, Mir Haji, and expelled their Barakzai Governor, Dost Mohammad's eldest son, Sardar Sher 'Ali Khan. They pursued him into his mud-walled compound in Charikar which they then besieged, 'tightening the noose around his neck'.[102] As a young man, Dost Mohammad had had many of the Kohistani maliks killed when he ruled the area for his elder half-brother Fatteh Khan, and having been offered financial inducements by Wade, Mir Haji now encouraged his people to rise up and claim the revenge for which they had been waiting twenty years.[103]

With one army advancing on him from Ghazni, and another from Jalalabad, and with the Kohistanis rising in revolt to his rear, Dost Mohammad's options were now rapidly diminishing. His first reaction was the traditional Pashtun response to a defeat – negotiations. Nawab Jabar Khan was the most pro-British of all the Kabul nobles: he had hosted Burnes and sponsored Charles Masson's excavations as well as sending his son to be educated in the English fashion at Wade's school in Ludhiana. Morever, during the face-off with Vitkevitch the previous year, the Nawab had worked hard to win over his brother to the British cause.

So Jabar Khan was sent to Ghazni with an offer – Shah Shuja could return to the throne, on the condition that under the Sadozai crown Dost Mohammad could continue as wazir, 'which situation, by hereditary claim, he had a right to secure'. After all, his half-brother Fatteh Khan had been wazir to Shah Zaman, and his father Payindah Khan was wazir to Shuja's father Timur Shah. To Pashtun eyes it was both the customary and the obvious solution to the problem, and Jabar Khan was amazed when the offer was peremptorily turned down by the British. He was also appalled at the rejection of his second request: 'the deliverance of his niece, the wife of Haidar Khan'. As one young British officer, Henry Havelock, noticed, Jabar 'felt or affected, the utmost indignation at the rejection'.[104] Only Mohan Lal, with his long experience of Afghan notions of honour, understood how insulting this rejection was: 'it was quite unnecessary to offend such a valuable friend as the Nawab at this critical time', he wrote. As a result,